

NEW-HOMEOWNER MAINTENANCE GUIDE

Stop Guessing. Start Protecting Your Home.

You bought the house. Congratulations. Now you own every pipe, every shingle, and every mystery sound the furnace makes at 2am.

If you've ever stared at a dark spot on the ceiling wondering if it's a \$50 fix or a \$5,000 emergency — you're not alone. You are in exactly the right place.

This guide gives you three things: a seasonal maintenance calendar, a repair triage decision tree, and a funding framework for year-one costs. No guesswork. No panic calls at midnight. Just a clear system you can follow the day you close.

THE CORE PROBLEM

You don't know what you don't know.

Home maintenance isn't taught in school. It isn't in your mortgage paperwork. And the people who would tell you — contractors, inspectors, agents — all have their own incentives.

The result is a well-documented pattern:

- First-year costs for new homeowners average **\$86,698** beyond the purchase price (source: NAHB and HUD cost studies, cited across home inspection industry)

- **29% of homeowners** say they delayed a maintenance task that eventually became a more expensive repair (2024 Angi/HomeAdvisor homeowner survey)
- The most common cost overruns: HVAC deferred maintenance, roof repair delays, plumbing leaks caught too late

The fix isn't a bigger emergency fund. It's a **triage mental model** so you stop guessing and start acting on facts.

PILLAR 1: THE SEASONAL MAINTENANCE CALENDAR

Most home systems run on a seasonal cycle. This calendar tells you what to check every 3 months — and what can wait.

SPRING (March–May)

Priority tasks: - Inspect roof for winter damage — look for missing shingles, ice dam residue - Clean gutters and downspouts (debris from winter) - Service air conditioning — replace filters, clear condenser coils - Check exterior caulking around windows and doors — re-seal if cracked - Test smoke and CO detectors — replace batteries if needed

Spring-specific warning: Foundation thaw means this is when you'll spot water intrusion most clearly. Watch basement walls and crawl spaces during the first heavy rain.

SUMMER (June–August)

Priority tasks: - Inspect and clean clothes dryer vent — leading cause of dryer fires is lint buildup - Check irrigation and outdoor plumbing for leaks - Seal deck and fence boards if needed — stain or sealant before fall - Test attic ventilation — look for signs of moisture or mold - Clean range hood filters and bathroom exhaust fans

Summer-specific warning: This is peak season for HVAC scam calls. If your AC goes out in July, you'll be desperate — and scammers know it. Know your AC unit's age and basic troubleshooting before you need it.

FALL (September–November)

Priority tasks: - Schedule furnace inspection — book in September, before the October rush - Clean gutters again — fall leaves are the heaviest debris load - Inspect weather stripping on all doors and windows — replace where cracked - Drain and winterize outdoor plumbing (unless in freeze-free climate) - Check pipe insulation in unconditioned spaces (basement, attic)

Fall-specific warning: The furnace inspection is the most important call you'll make all year. A \$150 inspection can prevent a \$3,000 emergency replacement in January.

WINTER (December–February)

Priority tasks: - Monitor your water bill — an unexpected spike signals a hidden leak - Keep a running list of everything you noticed in the other seasons that needs spring attention - Check for ice damming on roof edges — address in spring before they cause interior damage - Test sump pump if you have one — pour a bucket of water and verify it activates

Winter-specific warning: Frozen pipes are the #1 insurance claim in northern climates. Know where your main water shutoff is and how to use it.

PILLAR 2: THE REPAIR TRIAGE DECISION TREE

When something breaks or looks wrong, your first job is to answer three questions — in order. This tree works for 90% of homeowner repair decisions.

Step 1: Is It Dangerous Right Now?

NO → Proceed to Step 2

YES → Evacuate if gas/smoke/fire. Call 911. Stop here.

Step 2: Is It Getting Worse?

NO → Can it wait until normal business hours and a non-emergency appointment?

→ YES: Schedule a standard service call.

→ NO: Emergency window. See Step 3.

YES → Is it water or structural?

→ YES: Emergency. Call a licensed plumber or structural professional immediately.

→ NO: Same-day urgent. Call a service professional today.

Step 3: Is It DIY or Pro?

Use this decision matrix:

SITUATION	RECOMMENDATION
Under \$200, you understand the system, and you have the tools	DIY
Under \$500, you don't know the system, and a YouTube video explains it clearly	DIY with a friend
\$200–\$2,000 and you've gotten one independent quote	Get 2 more bids
Over \$2,000	Get 3 written bids minimum
Anything involving gas, electrical panels, or structural	Licensed professional only

How to Vet a Contractor (5-Point Check)

- 1. License + Insurance** — Ask for both. Verify at your state's contractor licensing board.
- 2. Local references** — Ask for 3 recent local jobs. Call them.
- 3. Written estimate** — Never accept a verbal quote over \$200.
- 4. No full payment upfront** — A reasonable deposit is 25–33%. The rest on completion.

5. **Scope in writing** — What exactly is being done? Materials? Disposal? Timeline?
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PILLAR 3: YEAR-ONE EMERGENCY FUND FRAMEWORK

The conventional wisdom is correct: set aside 1–3% of your home's purchase price for year-one costs. Here's how to think about it by tier.

Tier 1: Homes Under \$300,000

Target reserve: \$3,000–\$9,000 Realistic year-one items: - HVAC servicing: \$150–\$400 - Roof patching: \$300–\$1,200 - Plumbing callouts: \$150–\$600 per visit - Appliance repair/replacement: \$200–\$800 per unit - Unexpected: \$500–\$2,000

Tier 2: Homes \$300,000–\$600,000

Target reserve: \$6,000–\$18,000 Realistic year-one items: same categories, costs shift 30–50% higher depending on region.

Tier 3: Homes Over \$600,000

Target reserve: \$12,000–\$30,000 At this tier, luxury finishes and older systems compound. A failed boiler alone can hit \$8,000–\$15,000.

The Budget Allocation Framework

Use this split for your reserve fund: - **50%** — Immediate repair access (liquid savings) - **30%** — Planned seasonal service calls (separate line item each quarter) - **20%** — Contingency for what you missed in year one (rolls into year two budget)

THE INSPECTION CATCH-22

Your home inspection before closing identified things to monitor. But here's what most people miss: **the inspection is a moment in time, not a maintenance schedule.**

The things flagged as "monitor" need a tracking system. This is what that looks like:

ITEM FLAGGED	WHEN TO RECHECK	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Sealant cracking	Every 6 months	Moisture intrusion
Drainage slope	Every spring	Water pooling near foundation
HVAC age	Annually	Decreased efficiency, unusual sounds
Water stains on ceiling	After every heavy rain	Growth or spread

The best way to use your inspection report: create a simple spreadsheet. Column 1: item. Column 2: date flagged. Column 3: recheck date. Column 4: action taken. Update it once a month.

WHAT YOU CAN'T AFFORD TO IGNORE

These five items cause the majority of expensive homeowner emergencies:

- 1. Water heater over 10 years old** — Flush it annually. Replace at 12–15 years. Leak detection sensors are \$30 and prevent \$5,000 in water damage.
- 2. Clogged dryer vent** — Clean annually. More often if you dry heavy loads. Leading cause of house fires.
- 3. Roof over 15 years old** — Biannual inspection. Missing shingles are cheap to fix; a interior water claim is not.
- 4. Tree limbs overhanging roof** — Cut before storm season. One limb through a roof is \$10,000+.

5. Sump pump — Test every 3 months. Battery backup if you're in a flood-prone area.

NEXT STEPS

Here's where to go from here:

For New Users: Get the companion checklist version of this guide — the printable, checkbox-style edition you can tape to your utility wall. Available now in your Lemon Squeezy library at the link below.

For Existing Customers: Access your full member's area with all guides, checklists, and future updates at your member's area link.

Your Bonus: This guide is included in your Lemon Squeezy library at no additional cost. Check your library for companion materials and updates.

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